

Private hospitals' treatment of poor patients: An abdication

Delhi hospitals that have received land from the government on **concessional** rates **are** required to provide free services to patients from Economically Weaker Sections (EWS). The **percentage** of reserved beds and OPD consultations **varies** according to the **terms** of the lease agreements. However, the **breach** of such contracts **has** been a **persistent** worry for healthcare planners in the capital. In 2018, the Supreme Court **ruled** that **hospitals** failing to **comply with** their EWS-related **mandate** **could** **forfeit** their **lease**. The order **nudged** some hospitals to clean up their act. However, **by all accounts**, accessing private hospitals remains a challenging **proposition** for EWS patients. A major Delhi **hospital**, Indraprastha Apollo, **for instance**, **has** been among the **prominent defaulters** of the EWS clause. In March, the Supreme Court warned that it would **direct** the All India Institute of Medical Sciences to **take over** the private hospital if it did not **honour** its land lease agreement. The **deed**, which it had signed in 1988 with the then Lt Governor of Delhi, **enjoins** Apollo to **set aside** 200 beds for EWS patients. As an investigation by this newspaper shows, the hospital has **consistently fallen short of** this **commitment** in the past 12 years.

Apollo got land at a symbolic lease amount of Rs 1 per month. But it has used technicalities to **contest** the clause related to providing free treatment to the poor. In 2000, a Delhi government committee found that only 20 **beds** in the hospital **were** used by EWS patients. Then, in 2003, a committee **set up** by the Delhi High Court **highlighted** “discriminatory” methods, including not maintaining proper records, in the treatment of the poor. The HC again **censured** the hospital six years later and directed it to treat EWS patients “free of any expenses in relation to admission, bed, treatment, surgery, including consumables and medicines”. Apollo contested the verdict in the SC and argued that asking it to pay for consumables and medicines would “**wipe out** or reduce its dividend”. This paper’s investigation reveals that such claims are **grossly ill-founded** — in the past 12 years, the **occupancy** of EWS beds has never been more than a fifth of the **stipulated** figure.

In its latest order in the Apollo case, on March 24, the Supreme Court has asked the Centre and the Delhi government to set up a joint inspection team to check if the hospital has “**grabbed** land for private interest”. The two governments should use this experience to **put in place** procedures that ensure hospitals follow EWS-related rules. That the judiciary has been called to **intervene** at least five times in the past two **decades** to ensure **compliance** with these rules speaks poorly of the government’s monitoring **mechanisms**. Private hospitals in Delhi are among the chosen destinations for healthcare seekers from all parts of the country. A large number of these patients are from the poorer sections of society. They should not be forced to **seek** the Court’s **intervention** to access facilities which are rightfully **theirs**.

[Practice Exercise]

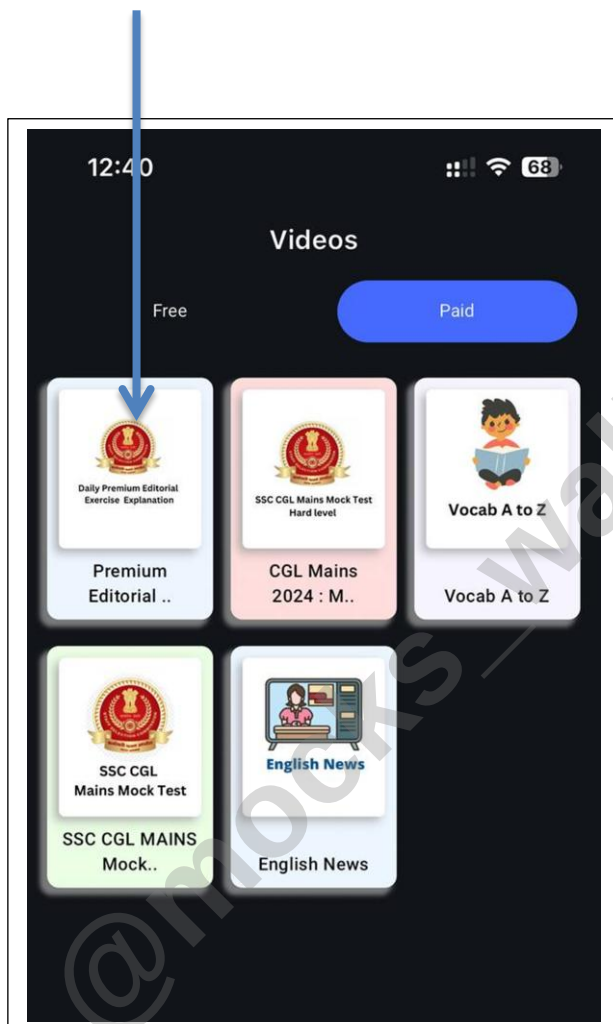
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where ‘red’ denotes ‘subject’ and ‘blue’ denotes ‘verb’.

Vocabulary

1. **Abdication** (noun) – renunciation, surrender, giving up, withdrawal, resignation त्याग
2. **Concessional** (adjective) – discounted, subsidized, reduced, preferential, cheaper रियायती
3. **Vary** (verb) – differ, change, fluctuate, modify, alter बदलना
4. **Terms** (noun) – condition, clause, provision, stipulation, agreement शर्त
5. **Breach** (noun) – violation, infraction, infringement, break, contravention उल्लंघन
6. **Persistent** (adjective) – continuous, constant, unrelenting, enduring, ongoing लगातार
7. **Rule** (verb) – decide, decree, judge, declare, pronounce निर्णय देना
8. **Comply** (with) (verb) – obey, follow, adhere, conform, respect पालन करना
9. **Mandate** (noun) – order, directive, instruction, command, authorization आदेश
10. **Forfeit** (verb) – lose, give up, surrender, relinquish, sacrifice ज़ब्त करना / खो देना
11. **Lease** (noun) – rental agreement, contract, tenure, letting, occupancy पट्टा
12. **Nudge** (verb) – prompt, push, encourage, urge, motivate प्रेरित करना
13. **By all accounts** (phrase) – according to reports, reportedly, as said, apparently, it seems सभी स्रोतों के अनुसार
14. **Proposition** (noun) – proposal, suggestion, idea, plan, offer प्रस्ताव
15. **For instance** (phrase) – for example, such as, like, to illustrate, say उदाहरण के लिए
16. **Prominent** (adjective) – well-known, noted, leading, famous, distinguished प्रमुख
17. **Defaulter** (noun) – non-payer, violator, transgressor, offender, debtor चूककर्ता
18. **Direct** (verb) – instruct, order, command, guide, tell आदेश देना
19. **Take over** (phrasal verb) – assume control, seize, acquire, occupy, usurp अधिग्रहण करना
20. **Honour** (verb) – fulfill, respect, abide by, carry out, obey पालन करना
21. **Deed** (noun) – legal document, contract, agreement, title, record कानूनी दस्तावेज
22. **Enjoin** (verb) – instruct, command, order, urge, require आदेश देना
23. **Set aside** (phrasal verb) – reserve, allocate, earmark, dedicate, keep आरक्षित करना

24. **Consistently** (adverb) – regularly, constantly, steadily, uniformly, persistently
निरंतर
25. **Fall short of** (phrase) – fail to meet, be insufficient, not reach, miss, underperform
कम पड़ना
26. **Commitment** (noun) – obligation, promise, responsibility, dedication, pledge प्रतिबद्धता
27. **Contest** (verb) – dispute, challenge, oppose, question, argue विरोध करना
28. **Set up** (phrasal verb) – establish, form, create, initiate, organize स्थापित करना
29. **Highlight** (verb) – emphasize, stress, underscore, point out, draw attention to
जोर देना
30. **Censure** (verb) – criticize, reprimand, condemn, rebuke, reproach निंदा करना
31. **Wipe out** (phrasal verb) – eliminate, destroy, remove, erase, exhaust समाप्त करना
32. **Grossly** (adverb) – excessively, extremely, hugely, blatantly, enormously अत्यधिक
33. **Ill-founded** (adjective) – baseless, unfounded, groundless, untrue, inaccurate
आधारहीन
34. **Occupancy** (noun) – usage, habitation, tenancy, use, residence अधिभोग
35. **Stipulated** (adjective) – specified, agreed, fixed, prescribed, stated निर्धारित
36. **Grab** (verb) – seize, take, snatch, appropriate, usurp हड़पना
37. **Put in place** (phrase) – implement, establish, arrange, institute, enforce लागू करना
38. **Intervene** (verb) – interfere, step in, mediate, intrude, intercede हस्तक्षेप करना
39. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years, दशक
40. **Compliance** (noun) – adherence, conformity, obedience, observance, agreement अनुपालन
41. **Mechanism** (noun) – system, process, method, procedure, setup प्रणाली
42. **Seek** (verb) – try, attempt, pursue, ask for, request प्रयास करना
43. **Intervention** (noun) – interference, involvement, mediation, intrusion, action हस्तक्षेप
44. **Theirs** (pronoun) – belonging to them, their one, of them, possessed by them उनका

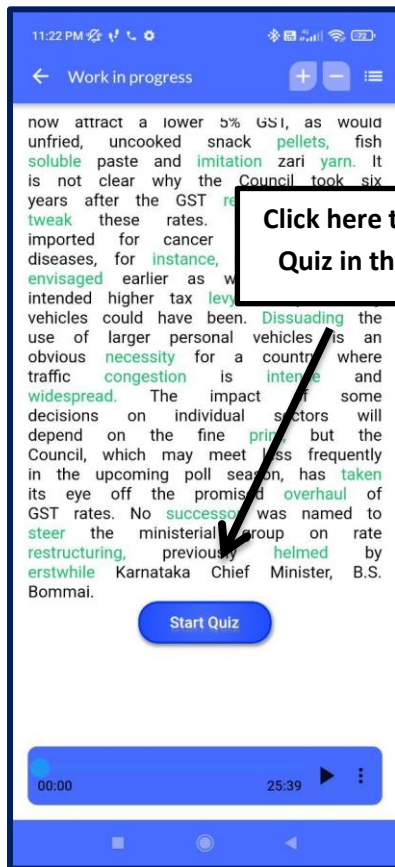
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



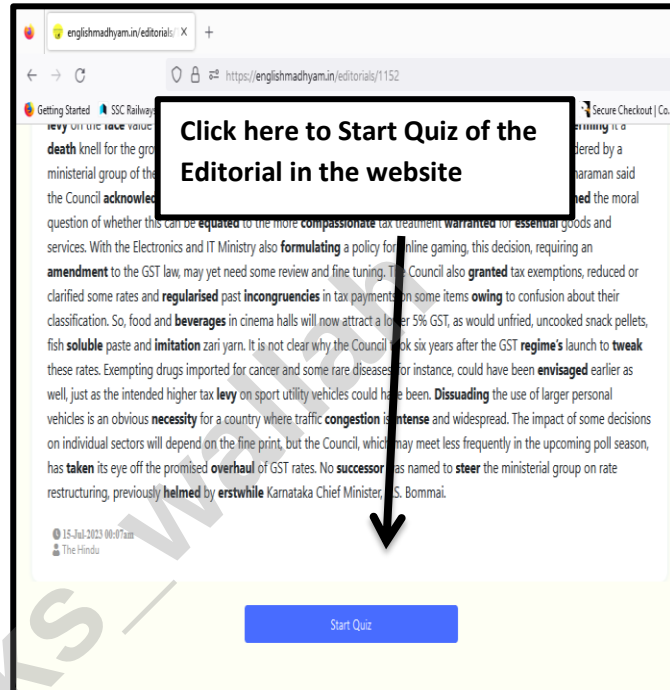
Summary of the Editorial

1. Private hospitals in Delhi that received land at concessional rates must reserve beds and OPD services for Economically Weaker Section (EWS) patients.
2. Compliance with this mandate has been consistently poor, raising concerns for healthcare planners.
3. The Supreme Court (2018) ruled that non-compliant hospitals could lose their leases, prompting some reforms.
4. Despite the ruling, EWS patients still face difficulty accessing services in many private hospitals.
5. Indraprastha Apollo Hospital is a key example of persistent non-compliance with its EWS obligations.
6. In March 2024, the Supreme Court warned Apollo that AIIMS could take over if it failed to meet its lease terms.
7. Apollo's original 1988 lease deed required it to reserve 200 beds for EWS patients.
8. An investigation shows that Apollo has consistently failed to meet this requirement for over a decade.
9. Apollo was allotted land at Rs 1 per month, but it used legal technicalities to evade the free-treatment clause.
10. A 2000 committee found only 20 beds used by EWS patients; a 2003 HC committee flagged discriminatory practices.
11. Delhi High Court in 2009 ordered the hospital to provide completely free treatment, including medicines.
12. Apollo contested this, claiming such requirements would affect its profits — a claim proven untrue by investigations.
13. Occupancy of EWS beds has never exceeded 20% of the required number over 12 years.
14. Supreme Court's latest order asked for a joint inspection to assess land misuse for private interest.
15. Repeated judicial interventions (at least five times) highlight the government's weak enforcement of EWS-related obligations.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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